Once I had settled in at ARTRAC HQ in Shimla, I put this proposal down on paper. Instead of having both Brigades and Divisions, we would have an intermediate organization, a 'Light Division'. I outlined this idea and tasked Brig Virender Vats, the BGS, to make a firm proposal.[1] Out of all the officers I had spoken to, he was possibly the first one who grasped the idea in its entirety. The Brigades would get their full complement of supporting arms and services on a permanent basis, rather than on mobilization, as is presently the case, and the Division HQ and Divisional Units would be done away with or repurposed (optimized). This would not only make the organization leaner and more operationally effective but also result in savings in manpower and the attendant recurring costs.

I presented this proposal during the Army Commanders' Conference in April 2018, using Sikkim as the tactical setting to illustrate the concept. However, three of the Army Commanders were those who had commanded either their Division or Corps in Sikkim, and they were totally opposed to this idea, terming it unpractical and compromising the defences of Sikkim. I had let it pass then, trusting their superior wisdom and knowledge of the terrain. I was not totally convinced, though. Later in the year, when I became the Army Commander, Eastern Command, I revisited this idea, for which I tasked Lt Cen CP Mohanty, the then 33 Corps Commander.[2] I gave him all the material I had from my earlier presentation, advising him that he could contact Maj Gen Virender Vats for additional inputs. Mohanty also grasped the concept immediately and felt it was absolutely doable, not only for Sikkim but for all of Eastern Command, particularly the isolated valleys in Arunachal Pradesh. He prepared a detailed presentation, reassigning units and formations as per the new concept and including an equally detailed plan showing the accretions and decrements in

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